

Spanish A1 — Week 9 Student Overview

Crescere | Beginner Spanish | Week 9

Theme: Plans and Obligations

What You Will Learn This Week

Week 9 is the week Spanish becomes genuinely useful for everyday life. You will learn the most natural way to talk about future plans — what you're going to do, when, and with whom. You'll also learn two essential structures for expressing what you have to do (*tener que* and *hay que*) and get more practice with *poder* for what you can or can't do. Combine them all, and you can have a real planning conversation in Spanish.

By the end of this week, you'll be able to discuss your plans, make arrangements, explain why you're busy, and suggest alternatives — the building blocks of any scheduling conversation.

What You Will Be Able to Say by the End of Week 9

Making a plan:

Esta noche voy a ir al cine con unos amigos. Mañana por la mañana tengo que trabajar, pero por la tarde estoy libre. La semana que viene vamos a ir de vacaciones.

Planning a social arrangement:

— *¿Estás libre este fin de semana?* — *Quiero ir, pero tengo que trabajar el sábado. ¡El domingo puedo!*
¿A qué hora quedamos? — *Quedamos a las tres delante del café.*

The Near Future: Ir a + Infinitivo

The simplest way to say what you're going to do is: **conjugated *ir* + a + infinitive of the main verb.**

You already know *ir* (*voy/vas/va/vamos/vais/van*). Just add *a* and the action:

Spanish	English
<i>Voy a trabajar mañana.</i>	I'm going to work tomorrow.
<i>¿Vas a llamar esta noche?</i>	Are you going to call tonight?
<i>Va a tomar el tren.</i>	He/she is going to take the train.
<i>Vamos a cenar juntos.</i>	We're going to have dinner together.
<i>No voy a salir esta noche.</i>	I'm not going to go out tonight.

This is how Spanish speakers talk about upcoming plans in everyday conversation. The grammatical future tense (*trabajaré*) exists but is more formal — for now, *ir a + infinitivo* covers everything you need.

Ir a vs. Pensar + Infinitivo

Structure	Feeling	Example
<i>Voy a + inf</i>	Definite plan	<i>Voy a llamarle esta tarde.</i> — I'm going to call him this afternoon.
<i>Pienso + inf</i>	Intention / idea	<i>Pienso llamarle.</i> — I'm thinking of calling him.

Both are useful. *Ir a* is more definite; *pensar* signals something is still an intention, not yet confirmed.

Pensar stem change (e→ie): *pienso, piensas, piensa, pensamos, pensáis, piensan*. Same pattern as *querer*.

Future Time Expressions

Spanish	English
mañana	tomorrow
esta noche	tonight
este fin de semana	this weekend
la semana que viene	next week
el mes que viene	next month
el año que viene	next year
en dos días	in two days
pronto	soon

The Three Obligation/Ability Structures

Structure	Meaning	Example
tener que + inf	personal obligation	<i>Tengo que trabajar mañana.</i>
hay que + inf	general obligation (no subject)	<i>Hay que reservar con antelación.</i>
poder + inf	ability / possibility	<i>Puedo venir a las 18h.</i>

Tener Que vs. Hay Que

The difference is simple:

- *Tengo que estudiar.* — I personally have to study.
- *Hay que estudiar.* — It's necessary to study / one must study (general rule).

Use *tener que* when the obligation applies to a specific person. Use *hay que* for general rules or necessities.

Combining the Structures

This is where planning conversations come alive:

Situation	Example
You want to but have to do something else	<i>Quiero venir, pero tengo que trabajar.</i>
You want to but can't	<i>Quiero venir, pero no puedo.</i>
You can if they want	<i>Puedo ir si quieres.</i>
General rule applies	<i>Hay que reservar — el restaurante se llena.</i>
You're going to have to cancel	<i>Voy a tener que cancelar — lo siento mucho.</i>

Key Planning Phrases

Spanish	English
<i>¿Qué vas a hacer este fin de semana?</i>	What are you going to do this weekend?
<i>¿Estás libre mañana?</i>	Are you free tomorrow?
<i>¿Quedamos cuándo / dónde?</i>	When / where shall we meet?
<i>¿A qué hora?</i>	At what time?
<i>Lo siento, no puedo.</i>	I'm sorry, I can't.
<i>¡Perfecto! / ¡Genial!</i>	Perfect! / Great!
<i>Quedamos a las...</i>	Let's meet at...

What to Practice Between Sessions

After Session 17 — before Session 18:

1. Say 3 plans for the coming week using *voy a + infinitivo*. Third try without notes.
2. Practice the time expressions until they come automatically: *mañana, esta noche, este fin de semana, la semana que viene*.
3. Try: say what you ARE going to do and what you are NOT going to do (*no voy a...*).

After Session 18 — before Session 19:

1. Write a short message to a (real or imaginary) Spanish-speaking friend proposing a plan. Include: *Voy a..., ¿Puedes...?, Tengo que..., No puedo... pero...*
2. Say the planning role play out loud from memory: suggest → hear no → negotiate → agree.
3. Learn *tengo que + your most common obligation* until it's automatic. *Tengo que trabajar. Tengo que estudiar. Tengo que volver a casa.*

A Note on Mistakes This Week

The most common error this week is **forgetting the a** in *ir a + infinitivo* — saying *voy trabajar* instead of *voy a trabajar*. The *a* is always required.

The second is **adding a preposition** after *tener que*: "*tengo que de trabajar*" — wrong. *Tengo que trabajar*. Same with *poder*: *puedo ir*, not *puedo a ir*.

The Writing Task for Sessions 17–18

The curriculum writing task for this week: *Write a short note making plans with a Spanish-speaking contact.* (4–6 sentences.) You'll use *ir a + infinitivo*, *tener que*, and ideally *poder*. Your homework will guide you through this.

Crescere — Spanish A1 Week 9 | Questions? Contact your instructor.